

The Android Success Story

Around 10 years back, when I got my first mobile phone, I hardly knew its operating system nor was I aware of its processor. I was just happy to have a 'mobile' phone. Today, the first consideration when getting a new phone is probably the operating system. This change in mindset can be attributed to Android and its huge app base. The advent of Android in the market has made people take notice of the operating systems on their phones.



So, what is it that makes Android click? Why is it that the Indian market, once dominated by the Finnish mobile giant Nokia, has swung the Android way of late? This article will look closely at the many reasons for this.

The early story

Andy Rubin, Rich Miner, Nick Sears and Chris White founded the company Android Inc in October 2003. They intended to develop an advanced operating system for digital cameras in the beginning, but later focused on mobile devices. Google acquired Android Inc in August 2005. This made clear Google's intentions of entering the mobile operating system market. Still, it took three years, till 2008, for the first Android device to be sold. During that time, there were interesting developments taking place. In 2007, the Open Handset Alliance or OHA was formed. This is a consortium of technology companies like Google; device manufacturers like Sony, HTC, and Samsung; and mobile network operators like Sprint and T-mobile. The goal was to develop open standards for mobile devices. This is why the Android OS was released as open source software.

How does it matter if the OS is open source or not?

Android is based on the Linux kernel and the OS code is available under the Apache licence (free to use and modify)

for anyone to download. This gave Android a unique advantage at the time of its release. Since it was the first such mobile operating system, developers and open source enthusiasts all over the world adopted it at an early stage and contributed to it. Let's not forget that Android is backed by what is probably the most innovative company on this planet.

Another innovation that Android brought in is the app-OS model for end users. It is not that this is completely new; older phones with the Symbian OS also allowed applications to be installed, but neither was there uniformity in the app development process, nor was it easy for the end user to find and install those apps. Android made it very easy for both the app developer community as well as users.

How is Android app development easier?

Anyone who has developed apps for the Symbian OS can answer this question! On a serious note, there are many things Google did, which made it easy for the developers to adopt the Android app development process. Here is a list of a few such things:

1. The first thing you would probably think of while planning to build an Android app is the IDE (Integrated Development Environment) or the tool to be used for app development. For Android, it is made available by Google. All that needs to be done is to just download the Eclipse IDE and install the Android developer tools plugin.